generic versions of patented drugs of multinational companies. The Indian biosimilar market is valued at around $12 billion (Rs 1.08 lakh crore) or 22 per cent of the total $55 billion (Rs 4.97 lakh crore) pharma market, and boasts such names as Biocon, Serum Institute of India, Bharat Biotech, Reliance Life Sciences and Dr Reddy's Laboratories. The market for biosimilars is growing at a CAGR of 20 per cent, per a 2025 report by the Biotechnology Industry Research Assistance Council (BIRAC).

THE FUTURE BET

- **India becomes global hub for manufacturing biosimilars**
- **Emergence of training, approval and clinical trials ecosystem**

"A great day for biopharma.... As India's disease burden shifts toward cancer, diabetes and autoimmune disorders, biologics and biosimilars will be central to improving longevity and quality of life... [The budget] initiatives can firmly position India as a global biopharma manufacturing hub"



— KIRAN MAZUMDAR SHAW, *Chairperson, Biocon*

Biopharma SHAKTI aims to create an entire ecosystem for domestic production of biosimilars. The strategy will include setting up three new National Institutes of Pharmaceutical Education and Research (NIPERs) and upgrading seven existing ones. A network of over 1,000 accredited India clinical trials sites is also proposed, as is strengthening the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation to meet global standards and approval time-frames through a dedicated scientific review cadre and specialists.

Sujay Shetty, global health advisory leader at PwC, considers the move a credible and powerful one for Indian biopharma. "Biopharma is a complex industry that requires more capital, and has challenges in transportation," he says. The current measures will improve India's competitiveness in the world biopharma market. China is already a leader, having built its capability over several decades, while in-licensing biologics from China is a major trend among American pharma firms, who will develop, manufacture or market the products in the US. India will take years to catch up with China and the developed world, but the announcements in this budget herald an encouraging start.

"A great day for biopharma. Thank you @nsitharaman for recognising the strategic importance of India's potential to be a global leader in biomanufacturing & biosimilars," Kiran Mazumdar-Shaw, chairperson of India's largest biotech company Biocon, posted on X. "As India's disease burden shifts toward cancer, diabetes and autoimmune disorders, biologics and biosimilars will be central to improving longevity and quality of life," she said, saying that the initiatives "can firmly position India as a global biopharma manufacturing hub". ■



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India Semiconductor Mission 2.0 seeks to anchor India in global supply chains

By **AJAY SUKUMARAN**